

Consent Form

School of Computing and Information Systems

Technology Innovation Project



Student Researchers: Anita Yang, Tammy Lee, Bella Chen, Leo Lin

Name of Participant: Mandy

1. I consent to participate in this project, the details of which have been explained to me, and I have been provided with a written plain language statement to keep.
2. I understand that the purpose of this research is to investigate how individuals seek and provide local help within their communities, and to evaluate the potential of a digital platform to improve accessibility, trust, and efficiency in connecting people with local support services.
3. I understand that my participation in this project is for research purposes only.
4. I acknowledge that the possible effects of participating in this research project have been explained to my satisfaction.
5. In this project I will be required to participate in a short interview or survey about my experiences with seeking or offering local help, and I may be asked to provide feedback on a prototype or concept of a digital platform.
6. I understand that my interviews may be audio recorded.
7. I understand that my participation is voluntary and that I am free to withdraw from this project anytime without explanation or prejudice and to withdraw any unprocessed data that I have provided.
8. I have been informed that the confidentiality of the information I provide will be safeguarded subject to any legal requirements; my data will be password protected and accessible only by the named researchers.
9. I understand that given the small number of participants involved in the study, it may not be possible to guarantee my anonymity.
10. I understand that after I sign and return this consent form, it will be retained by the student researchers.

Participant Signature: Mandy, H **Date:** 29/03/2026

Interview Guide — Australia Hero

Estimated duration: 20–30 minutes **Format:** Semi-structured (follow up naturally on interesting answers)

Opening Script (read aloud)

"Hi, thanks for taking the time to speak with us today. We're a group of postgraduate students from the University of Melbourne working on a project called Australia Hero — a hyper-local platform that helps community members and students exchange small tasks and resources nearby. Before we start, you'll have received our Plain Language Statement explaining the project. Do you have any questions about it? [Pause] Great. I'd also like to ask your permission to audio record this conversation so we can review it later — is that okay? [Pause for consent form signing] Let's begin."

Section 1 — Background (3–4 min)

Goal: understand who the person is and their living context.

1. Can you tell me a bit about yourself — what you're studying or doing, and how long you've been living in your current area?
 2. How would you describe your relationship with your neighbours or the people around you?
-

Section 2 — Current Behaviours (5–7 min)

Goal: uncover real, recent experiences — not hypotheticals.

3. Think about the last time you needed help with something small — maybe borrowing something, moving a piece of furniture, or running an errand. What did you do?
 - *Follow up: Why did you choose that approach? Did it work out?*
4. Have you ever had a moment where you needed help but didn't know who to ask, or felt uncomfortable asking? Can you walk me through that situation?
5. Have you ever helped someone nearby — a neighbour, classmate, or stranger? What was that like?
 - *Follow-up: What motivated you to help? Would you do it again?*

Section 3 — Challenges & Pain Points (5 min)

Goal: validate and deepen the problem.

6. When you try to find help — whether through apps, social media, or friends — what's the most frustrating part of that process?
 7. Have you ever used a platform like Facebook groups, Nextdoor, or WhatsApp groups to ask for or offer help? What worked well, and what didn't?
 8. As an international student or someone new to the area, have you ever felt you lacked a local support network for small everyday things? Can you give an example?
-

Section 4 — Reactions to the Platform Idea (5–7 min)

Goal: gauge genuine interest and surface concerns.

[Brief explanation: "Our platform lets you post small help requests on a map — like borrowing a tool or asking for help moving a box — and nearby people can respond. There's also a reputation and reward system to build trust."]

9. What's your initial reaction to this idea?
 10. Can you imagine a situation in your own life where you'd actually use something like this? What would that look like?
 11. What would make you hesitant to use it — or stop using it after trying it once?
 - *Follow up: What would need to be true for you to feel safe interacting with a stranger through this platform?*
-

Section 5 — Trust, Safety & Incentives (5 min)

Goal: understand what builds confidence and motivates participation.

12. What would make you trust someone enough to accept help from them or offer help to them on this platform?
13. If there were a points or reputation system — where you earned recognition for helping — would that motivate you, or would it feel artificial? Why?
14. Would you prefer to remain somewhat anonymous on this platform, or would you want your real identity visible? What's your reasoning?
15. When receiving help or offering help, do you have any personal preferences regarding the helper or requester (e.g., gender, age, or other factors)?

- *Follow up:* Do you feel more comfortable interacting with someone of a particular gender in certain situations? (describe the situation)
16. Does this preference also apply when you are the one offering help to others?
-

Section 6 — Feature Priorities (3 min)

Goal: prioritise MVP features based on real user input.

17. If you could only have two or three features on this platform when it first launched, what would they be and why?
18. Is there anything you've seen in another app — not necessarily in this space — that you think would work really well here?
-

Closing (1–2 min)

19. Is there anything else about this kind of platform — or your own experiences with getting or giving help — that you think we should know?

"Thank you so much for your time. Your answers are really valuable to us. Just as a reminder, your responses will be kept confidential, referred to by a pseudonym in any reporting, and you can withdraw at any time. We'll be in touch if we have any follow-up questions."

Tips for Your Team

Before the interview: Have the Consent Form and Plain Language Statement ready. Let the participant read the PLS first, then sign the consent form before recording begins.

During: Don't rush past good stories — if someone gives a rich example, ask "can you tell me more about that?" The best insights come from specifics, not generalities.

Divide and conquer: One person asks questions, another takes notes. Rotate roles across interviews.

Target participants: Prioritise international students for interviews, as your proposal identifies them as the primary user group with the most acute pain points.

Q1

Location and Duration

Participant Profile

Demographics & Context

- **Name:** Mandy
- **Status:** International postgraduate student
- **Academic Progress:** Third semester in Melbourne City
- **Current Location:** Docklands
- **Duration of Residence:** Living in Docklands for 1 year
- **Personality:** Self-described as "quite a introverted guy"

Q2

Current Situation & Challenges

- Lacks established relationships with neighbors
- Almost never seems like neighbors in current living arrangement
- Attributes distance to Melbourne being "like a country jungle" with different lifestyles and unfamiliarity

Q3

Task Examples & Approaches

- **Recent Task:** Changed sofa and moved new sofa into house (physical task requiring assistance)
- **Current Approach:** Asks friends for help
- **Challenge:** Requires arranging and scheduling time with friends, which is inconvenient

Q4

- Limited local support network for everyday tasks as international student
- Finds it awkward and uncomfortable to post for help online due to introversion
- "I'm quite a introverted guy I really never post something website. I think it's a little bit awkward to ask for help online."

Q5

Never, since never talked to neighbour during her daily life

Q6

Usually, won't ask for help online. Prefer to ask friends. But in the emergency situation:

Decision-Making in Emergency

- Default approach: Wait for friends to become available
- Emergency situations: Willing to post online for help if truly necessary
- Willing to overcome introversion when help is urgent

Q7

Platform Usage Experience

- Familiar with Facebook, primarily for searching second-hand items
- Never posts on Facebook marketplace
- Unaware of Nextdoor platform before interview
- Does not use other community platforms like WhatsApp groups for requesting help

Q8

Feel lack supported from local community as the newcomer.

Q9

Care about the review and comment on the platform, since she prefer to receive or give help for the people who have the higher rate or score in our platform. Comment can be useful for verifying this person indeed give the help.

Q10

- **Unmet Need:** Had broken fridge with food inside and needed place to store food, wanted to ask neighbor but didn't know them

Q11

Trust & Safety Concerns

Primary Safety Issue

- "I think the most important issue is the safe. It's the safety issues. Security issue? Yeah, because I need to let strangers come into your house."
- Main hesitation: Allowing unknown people into home for physical tasks
- (Anita told her) We will have the log in system to ensure that the users make the consent form and verify the identity

Q12

Verification Requirements

- **Positive regarding:** Google account connection for identity verification
- Feels safer with documented profiles rather than fully anonymous interactions

Q13

- Views reputation system as trust indicator: "if you have a good impression, it would be more safe for me"

Q14

Identity Preferences

- Prefers **visible identity** on platform for increased safety
- Willing to display personal information (gender, age) if it helps assess trustworthiness
- Recognizes reciprocal nature: "if you want to see others you might have to show others your age at the same time"

Q15

Gender & Task-Specific Preferences

- **Gender preference not absolute:** "It doesn't matter" for most situations
- **Context-dependent:** Prefers female helpers for general tasks but male helpers for physically demanding tasks
- **Priority ranking:**
 - **First priority:** Task type determines helper preference
 - **Second priority:** Gender preference based on task
- "it depends on the task...if I think this task is more um I need more like um the man oh the power the power stuff. I would choose the man."
- **Age:** Not a significant factor in trust decisions
- **Time-based filtering:** Suggested feature where users can restrict requests to same-gender helpers after 10 p.m. (for safety)
- **Physical capability consideration:** When requiring genuine physical strength, task requirements override gender preference

Q16

Same as above.

Q17

Feature Priorities & User Preferences

Top Priority Features

1. **Tooltip/tooltip information:** Small informational pop-ups when clicking map markers
2. **Notification system:** Push notifications for friend requests
3. **Search functionality:** Ability to search within the platform
4. **Review/comment system:** User feedback and comments on exchanges
5. **Avatar customization:** Ability to create personalized profile avatars

Q18

Desired Features NOT Seen as Necessary

- No identified features from other apps (Facebook, Nextdoor) specifically wanted to be added
- "I think nothing" when asked about features from other apps to incorporate

Q19

Feature Concerns

- Won't have notification stress
- Participant notes ability to decline with excuse ("I can say I'm busy")
- Team discusses this concern with some participants experiencing stress from obligations

Transcript:

Thank you for taking your time to speak to us today. We are a group of postgraduate students from the University of Melbourne working on a project called Helpmet. Like you see on this page, this is a hyper-local platform that helps community members and students experience more tasks and resources nearby. Before we start, we will have received our plan language statement explaining the project. Do you have any question about it? No. Great! That's awesome! I would also like to ask your permission to audio recall these conversations so we could review it later. Is that okay? Yeah, sure. Yeah, okay. Okay, let's begin. For section one, that's like... tell me about yourself a little bit and can you tell me about yourself where you are what you are doing now you are studying or working now and how long have you been how long have you living in your current area and that's her degree and this is my third semester in Melbourne city and I have been living in Docklands for a year for a year for a year yeah How does you feel for living in a dark place? I love here because I love the vibe around the darkness and it's quite chill for living here. Yeah, that's good. How would you describe your relationship with your neighbor or the people around you have you met someone like your neighbor before? I have to say I almost never seem like um neighbors mm-hmm that's nice one yeah that's fine yeah because you you know like melbourne is like a country jungle everyone's here also like i don't know how to say we have different i think we have different lifestyles yeah yeah yeah yeah we are both unfamiliar with like each other yeah yeah that's that's okay that is why our apps comes comes to place yep that's good Okay, now let's talk about our behavior in our daily life. Think about it, last time you needed help with something small. Maybe borrowing something, moving a piece of furniture around in the iron. What did you do? Can you share some experience with me? Last

month... we changed the sofa and we throw our sofa away also put away and we move the new sofa in our house so you mean that uh like this kind is about the physical task like you need someone help for moving in or moving out right yeah at the time we asked for our friends for help like Which platform like you use like what's it? Well, we use what's out. Oh, okay. That's good Friends. Yeah How do you think that like this approach The benefit of this approach like X people X your friend is that convenient or it's immediately solve your problem It's not That's convenient because asking book friends we should like arrange some time with them, right? Yeah, we need to arrange time. Let's schedule like and see if they are available. It's not that inconvenient. Yeah, it's inconvenient. Have you ever had a moment where you needed help but didn't know who to ask or feel uncomfortable for asking help from others? Can you walk me through that situation? Yeah. Like, last month we broke our fridge. Yeah, yeah, yeah. And we don't, like, we still have food in our fridge and we don't know where to... keep that food fresh so we will need to ask for somebody to put our food but it's quite inconvenient to ask friend so um i really want to ask a neighbor i think at the time i really want to ask for a neighbor's house but i don't know i don't need any neighbors So yes. Yeah, this is a tough question. Yeah. Have you ever helped someone one year by a neighbor or your classmate or stranger? What was it like? Like you never met someone you help in your apartment. Around the apartment. Hmm, probably make them because you're only here for a year. Yeah, right. Yeah, that's easy. So Let's talk about the challenging for asking help from others like your pinpoint When you try to find help whether through apps social media or friends, what is the most frustrating part of that process? Because I'm quite a introverted guy I I really I really never post something website. I think it's a little bit awkward to ask for help online. So this is the most struggled thing I think. But if you need help, you really need to solve that problem, like you expect from acting your friend, what would you do? Like just give up or like wait until your friend are available or something. I think I will wait. for my friends. But how about that? In the immediate emergency situation? On emergency, I think I will post. Wait, would you like to talk about your network? I think if I really need to, I will. Okay, okay. Have you ever used a platform like Facebook? Nextdoor, do you know, do you have everything that Nextdoor, this app or website? I know Facebook, but I do it next door Next door is a platform that allows you to meet your neighbour Yeah, it's kind of... I have that question, but I don't know Yeah, that's okay Okay, so You mentioned that you use Facebook Which function you use on the Facebook? You're just browsing or you actually post something on the Facebook for... like in the marketing place. I never post anything on marketing place but I have I used to like search the second hand things on Facebook. As an international student like you have you feel you like a local support network for small everyday things? because as international students and the introverted guys I think it's a little bit like a small trouble for me if I have anything to ask for help Yeah, that's how we how our apps come to solve the problem that you face. Okay. That's it's time It's time for me to let me introduce our apps for you This is our apps called Helpmat can keep you safe. It's what it's like It actually it works that is name like okay Let me show you This is how our daily life questions that we might face, like resource to waste, like if you borrow something, if you buy something that only use once and never use it again, but you borrow it, it wastes. It occupies the place in your house, but you never use it, it wastes the resource. And another question is like physical test, like you are... Like, I know you are a girl, and sometimes moving out, we really need physical help from, like, guys. That which is more powerful, more, yeah, that can help us, but we probably not met anyone, or not, like, familiar with your neighbor, like, who can give us some help. So, that is... Question that we face and also including about knowledge need that if you face that technical issue like Yeah, yeah like if You your company is shut down But you have you have to submit your assignment as soon as possible Yeah, yeah, yeah, but you don't know how to do that. It's time for our act. Yeah. Yeah, and After security is an app and it based on the map it will it will have the markers in in the map and you can see like the need the need the need help like require will be the red marker and the supplier will be the green marker and you'll you will be the yellow one and and there there will be a filter to that the user filter like if you need any kind of help or you want to see a little supplier part. And this map is basically based on the local community, like the neighbour around you. It's probably used for you to like have a chance to make friends with your neighbors. Like if you are continuously working quite well with your neighbors, like you give them some help and in return she or someone also give you some help, you have a chance to make friends with them. There is a friend system in our app. Like it gives you a chance not how it works like you can you can know each other and you can leave your contact information to them like you can use your Instagram or like WhatsApp to them and you can not only use this platform and like you have more chance to make more people around you Yeah Yeah In order to solve the authentic issue and verification issue, we have the leading board which make people to give the local community more help than the one with the most frequently helped will have the credit or the score to make it be the top of the

leaderboard. yeah yeah yeah yeah yeah like ranking yeah and it would renew every week you will not always be the top one and it it was solve the issue about like you doesn't you might not trust someone some stranger yeah No, if you think about everyone like from the money part, no, there is no benefit of money, but if we create, we image that if you are the top five, maybe you can get the life. Because in our app, we have the profile, right? And everyone have an avatar. And if you be a leader or top five of the ranking, of your ranking you might get some like suit or some uh equipment of your avatar mm-hmm like it's it's quite like a gamified app if you saw this this problem and you can get something like cool stuff yeah that is how our apps looks like yeah it's time for you to tell me about your initial store I need your idea about having about after you listen to like our app Can I leave any reviews in your app? Like for help or for asking help or for helping others Can I leave any reviews? Yes, yes We will have this like function like after you After you giving someone's help or asking someone help and after that you can have leave a comment for that the user we only have good comment like good song or bad song like if This person really give you the good Help and you can give her give them I think this is quite hard. I think this is quite hard. For those who are in trouble. In trouble. Not connecting with the local community. Yeah, not connecting to a lot of people. I think that is really useful. Yeah, and can you imagine a situation that you would use this app? I need to change some like bones. Like physical tasks that you cannot solve alone. Yeah, that is why our apps want to solve, right? Like, what would make you hesitate to use it or stop using it after trying it once? I think the most important issue is the safe. It's the safety issues. Security? Security issue? Yeah, because I need to let strangers come into your house. I think that is the most important issue for me. Mm-hmm, but how about like we have the verification for identity like we Need to connecting make user to connecting with their Google account Or need the password to log in would you all this function helps? Yeah Like and there is an extension question like Would you prefer to marry someone? somewhat anonymous on this platform or would you want your real identity visible? I think I would choose identity visible because I think it would be more safe but like you can see others gender age or something like this one but how about yourself would you prefer to show others your like Gender age because if you want to see others you might have to show others your age at the same time I think it will be okay. It will be okay Okay, okay, yeah That's good, okay, let's talk about trust and safety issue Would you make what would you make you trust someone enough to accept help from them or over help to over help to them on this platform. Like I mentioned before, like the login system and any other things that you can come up with. If there were a point of reputation system, would you earn recognition for helping? Would that motivate you or would it feel artificial? Like the score of the leaderboard, would it be like quite useless? Would you think that it's useless? I think it's quite useful as for the users to... to decide if this person is trustable. Yeah, it's like... I think it's like a reputation. It's like if you have a good impression, it would be more safe for me. Yeah, yeah, yeah. Cool. When receiving help or opening help, do you have any personal preference regarding the helper or the request like gender, age, or other factors? Like first, like gender. Would you prefer the female or the male? For help. Oh, it doesn't matter. I have to say, I would prefer female. But if I have to move some, like, hey, big. Stuff I would consider No, it depends on the task, right? Yeah. Yeah, not but like if How about if we have a function like after 10 p.m You can only pick like female can only pick the female We call it require all the supplier. Will you be helpful for like you trust this platform better? But I think if You still need a physical task, you still need a... If someone's... It's really like this emergency issue, I think we should... We still need to... Ask the person who will provide that physical help. Yes. Yeah, okay. How about the age? Would you... I think that age is not the problem. Okay. And is there any other factors that would affect you too? Like... Like, regarding the helper or requester? I think... No, I just care about the trend. Okay. Okay. How about the distance? Distance? Like, if there are two suppliers close to you, would you prefer the female that is like... far from you or the male that is closer from you me I think I would choose it depends on the task yeah so depends on the task if I think this task is more um I need more like um the man oh the power The power stuff. I would choose the man. I would choose. It depends on the gender. It depends on the distance. So the first priority, filter will be the spot. Gender. Gender? Not a task. Oh yeah, task is my priority. First priority. First one and second will be the gender. If you could only have one or three features on this platform when you first launched, what would they be? I think I will come soon. Oh, like tour tip, like the small information. When you click the markers, it will jump out. Oh, I like the notification. The notification? Yeah. If like your friends need help, it will push the notification to you to remind you that your friends need help. Yeah, yeah, yeah. I think that is quite useful. But would it be stressful if you see your friends need help but you actually don't want to help them? No, because my friends don't know But if they know you are using the app But I can say I'm busy I can say I'm busy. I'm working on my schoolwork. Okay. Yeah, you won't feel stressful, right? I won't. Yeah. Yeah, because in our team we discuss this problem. Okay. Yeah. Yeah. So somebody feels stressful. Yeah, if they

didn't give, if they won't give their friends help. But now the features that you would like, This one's in our app. I think it's the... How about the search bar? The search bar and the comment sphere. The comment and review? Yeah, the comment and review. Okay. And the cute profile. You like the avatar? You can create your own avatar, right? Yeah. Yeah, okay. And is there any things you have seen in a lot of apps that you want to add in our apps? Another app? Yeah, like in the Facebook or in the Red North? I think... nothing. Nothing? Yeah, yeah, good. In the next question, is there any else that you want to share with me about the platform or the feedback after hearing my small presentation? Small presentation? A little presentation. Really? Thank you. I also like your ideas because this is quite useful book. for like international students and someone who is new for this city. Yeah, it's quite useful. Yeah, thank you. Great. Yeah, thank you. Thank you. Thank you for all the questions.